

leveraging a mix of freeware or open source components and custom components.

Recommendation: Before deciding on which open source tools and libraries to leverage, a precise check on their capabilities, roadmap, support services and costing, long term plans, customisation possibilities and licence type will help you in taking the most appropriate decision.

The MADP advantage

Enterprises leverage MADPs to get the benefits of one or more of the following salient features.

Excellent support for cross-platform mobile app development

This feature addresses the mobile platform diversity challenge by providing a way to write selected or common code/scripts for mobile app development targeted at all platforms. Internally, the platform may use a variety of approaches to convert the common code to platform-specific apps.

Many MADPs like PhoneGap provide a hybrid development framework, which provides the best of the Web (also known as thin client) and native (also known as thick client) approaches. It facilitates communication between the Web and the native parts of the app along with other rich features. This paradigm is characterised by the reuse of Web parts across mobile platforms while balancing the native approach benefits.

There are also MADPs like Appcelerator, which consist of inbuilt converters to convert the common script written by MADP developers into platform-specific native apps. In short, MADPs help to optimise the time, effort and cost of maintaining apps for multiple platforms.

Recommendation: MADPs differ in their support for specific mobile platforms and scripting languages, and come with their own limitations. An enterprise must analyse its existing or long-term preferred skill sets, vendor binding limitations and target mobile platforms to better judge which MADP suits it the best. It would also help to get a complete overview of the vendor MADP roadmap and match it with your enterprise's mobile app feature needs, in case you choose a standard MADP solution.

The standard MADP solutions roadmap and features are influenced by a variety of factors and your enterprise feature requirements may or may not match with them. This is why a large number of enterprises prefer customised MADPs to avoid vendor binding and to gain complete control as per their app roadmap, while keeping the solution simple and targeted to their specific needs.

Easy integration with standard enterprise data sources

This feature addresses the enterprise data access challenge to a large extent. Enterprise data sources may be standard

like SAP, Salesforce, JDEdwards, etc, or customised.

While MADPs provide loosely coupled and clean ways to integrate standard data sources, if custom data source integration is required, it would consume effort and time, depending on the complexity of integration.

Recommendation: Different MADPs feature integration with different sets of data sources. An enterprise looking for a MADP must map its specific data source integration needs with the data sources supported by MADPs, to take an appropriate decision.

Always think in terms of the future roadmap in order to cover the bigger picture of the mobility solution.

The power to manage the mobile app's lifecycle

This feature addresses the remote management challenge to some extent. While enterprises have a collection of apps planned or rolled out for different target user bases, rolling out and managing multiple apps for multiple platforms together with multiple versions of each becomes a huge challenge for the enterprise.

MADP solves this challenge by helping to design, develop, test, deploy, distribute, analyse and manage a portfolio of cross-platform mobile apps on a range of devices. In short, it brings all mobile app lifecycle related operations together in one solution for ease of management.

Recommendation: Different MADPs support different approaches, standards and tools for achieving the different lifecycle processes. The enterprise must match its existing tools and processes to the MADPs in consideration before taking the final call.

Easy integration with cloud services and third party tools

This feature addresses the dual challenges of enterprise data access and security. An enterprise may be leveraging certain cloud services and its data may reside on the cloud for a certain category of ecosystem components. Further, it may leverage third party tools of mobility management like Airwatch, MobileIron, etc. The enterprise mobile app must integrate well with these heterogeneous sources of data and the management tools.

Many MADPs consider this crucial need and provide good support for easy integration with these third party services.

Recommendation: The enterprise needs to understand its existing ecosystem and processes, together with its needs relating to third party tools integration with respect to MADP, before taking the final call. 

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